

Lecture 2: What is government? What is politics?

GOVT2305: Federal Government

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0.1 Today

- What is Government? What is politics?
- Discussion: Experiences with Government
- Questions

1. Why This Matters

1.1 Why This Matters

By the end of today you will be able to explain why government is the only organization that can legally force you to do something against your will.

1.2 The Core Question

What makes government different from every other group of people who try to get things done?

1.3 Before You Walked Onto Campus

Before stepping on the campus today, what was the last time that politics made a difference in your life?

2. A Word on Words

2.1 Government

- The specific group of people in charge right now
- The enduring institution or organization we call government

2.2 State

- International: State = independent country
- United States: State = one of the 50 states
- Political Science: State = government

2.3 Politics

The process of making collective decisions in the context of the state or government

3. What Do Most People Think Politics Is?

3.1 What Do Most People Think Politics Is?

- Expensive or involves large amounts of money
- Distant

- Involves politicians or campaigns
- Involves voting or decision making
- Involves rights
- National borders
- Controversial

3.2 What Is Politics: State and Local



Houston Public Works

3.3 What Is Politics: Federal, State and Local



Metro rail

3.4 What Is Politics: Federal, State and Local



HCC Central Campus

3.5 What Politics Actually Is

- Not distant

- Immediate, right here
- Touches everything
- Direct impacts are constant
- Involves all of us
- It can be expensive, but it is not always about money

4. Politics Is Powerful

4.1 Politics Is Powerful

- Immense power to achieve good ends

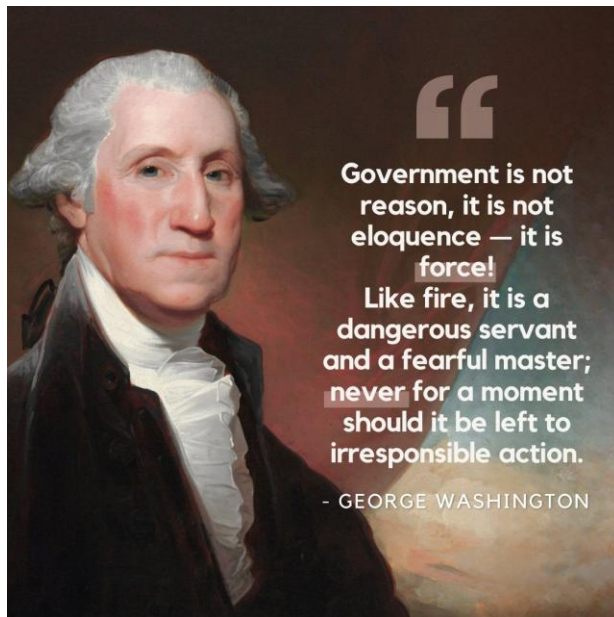
4.2 Politics Is Powerful

- Immense power to achieve good ends
- Immense power to do incredible harm

4.3 Politics Is Powerful

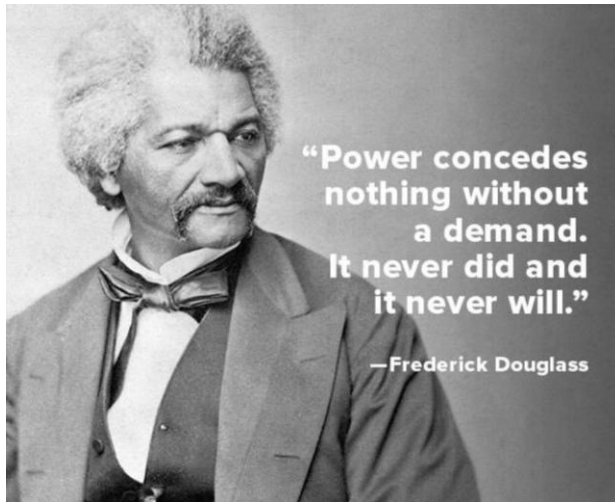
Why does politics have
such power to cause harm?

4.4 Politics Is Powerful



George Washington

4.5 Politics Is Powerful



Frederick Douglass

4.6 Power

Power

5. Collective Action

5.1 What Does Government Do?

These are all examples of *collective action* — organized action by a group of people to achieve a common goal.

5.2 What Makes Government Different?

What makes government or The State different from other organizations?
Is collective action unique to government?

6. Other Organizations

6.1 Other Organizations — Group 1

- Family

6.2 Other Organizations

- Family
- Church

6.3 Other Organizations

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)

6.4 Other Organizations

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)
- Charities

6.5 Other Organizations

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)
- Charities
- Businesses — The Market

6.6 Other Organizations — Group 2

- Organized crime

6.7 Other Organizations

- Organized crime
- Vigilantes

6.8 Other Organizations

- Organized crime
- Vigilantes
- Terrorists

6.9 Key Questions

- For Group 1 organizations:
How can they enforce their rules?
- For Group 2 organizations:
Who are they responsible to,
and how do we view their use of force?

7. The State

7.1 What Is “the State”?

The organized, coercive use of violent force commonly accepted as legitimate

- Organized
- Coercive use
- Violent force (armed force)
- Legitimacy

7.2 What Is Politics?

Politics is the process of making collective decisions in the context of...

7.3 What Is Politics?

Politics is the process of making collective decisions in the context of the State or government.

7.4 The Difference

These organizations all engage in collective action, but lack one thing the state has:

- Family
- Church
- Community organizations (voluntary)
- Charities
- Businesses — The Market

Coercive use of violent force

7.5 Two Spheres

Voluntary Sphere

Family, church, market, charities...

Coercive Sphere

The State

7.6 Politics Is About

Making collective decisions in
the Coercive Sphere

8. Canvas and e-Book Overview

9. Questions

9.1 Next Lecture & Reminders

Next class (August 24): Basic Ethics

Come prepared to discuss *your own* answers to these questions.
We will start with them. Legal answers are not what we are after.

- What are ethically appropriate uses of physical force (violence)?
- How do you (or how should you) make ethical decisions?
- If you have to make a decision that affects the lives or property of others, how do you determine right from wrong when the law is silent or absent?

Following class (August 26): Begin Constitutional Safeguards

9.2 Upcoming Due Dates

- Module 0 substantially complete by **August 30** (avoid drop)
- Module 1 Study Guide and Connect due **September 18**
- Module 1 Quiz – In Class **September 21**

9.3 Authorship and License

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